THE "EVERYONE ELSE HAS IT" PROBLEM

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

CYBER SAFETY GUY

Kids want what their friends have. It's normal. But "everyone else" isn't always a good reason. Here's what parents need to know.

73% of teens feel pressure to keep up with friends online — Pew Research (2022)

2x teens are more likely to ask for tech when friends have it — Common Sense (2022)

45% of teens say they feel left out when they can't join in — Nielsen (2023)

1 IN 3 teens say seeing others with new tech makes them want it more — Piper Sandler (2023)

1 THE NEED TO BELONG

Kids don't want to feel left out. Belonging is powerful—especially in middle school and high school.

2 SOCIAL PRESSURE IS REAL

When friends have something, it can feel like you need it too to fit in.

3 COMPARISON HURTS

Constant comparing leads to stress, low self-esteem and "not enough" thinking.

4 IT'S NOT JUST ABOUT THE STUFF

It's about status, access, games, features, and being part of the convo.

5 MARKETING MAKES IT WORSE

Ads, influencers and trends push the idea that new = better (and you need it).

6 MISSING OUT IS REAL

FOMO

Fear of Missing Out (FOMO) can push kids to say "yes" to unsafe choices.

WHAT KIDS ARE REALLY THINKING

- If I don't have it, they'll think I'm weird.
- They'll stop inviting me.
- What if I miss something important?
- Everyone else has it.
- It's how we hang out.
- It's not fair. Not fair.

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

- It's not just about the device or app. It's about connection and acceptance.
- Saying "no" without a plan can make your child feel more isolated.
- Kids need boundaries—and support—to handle social pressure.
- You can teach them confidence, critical thinking and digital balance.

Your guidance today builds their confidence tomorrow.

BY THE NUMBERS

64% of teens feel pressure to keep up with trends online — Common Sense (2022)

57% of parents say their child asks for tech because friends have it — Pew Research (2023)

40% of teens say they compare their life to others online daily — Nielsen (2023)

3+ HOURS per day teens spend on social media on average — DataReportal (2024)

SMART WAYS TO RESPOND

1. Acknowledge their feelings. "I get why this matters to you."
2. Ask questions. "What do you think having it will help you do?"
3. Set clear boundaries. Based on safety, age and values.
4. Offer options. "Let's find another way to stay connected."
5. Teach delay, not denial. Help them wait without shame.
6. Build real-world confidence. Skills > status.

TALK ABOUT IT: TRY THESE CONVERSATION STARTERS

- What do you think makes everyone want the same things?
- How do you feel when your friends have something you don't?
- What's most important to you—fitting in or being yourself?
- How can we handle social pressure together?
- What can you do when you feel left out?

HELP THEM BUILD INNER STRENGTH

- Remind them what makes them unique.
- Celebrate effort, not "stuff".
- Encourage activities that build real confidence.
- Model contentment and balance.
- Teach them that "enough" is a superpower.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

- "You are enough."
- "People who matter don't mind."
- "You don't need the latest to be your best."
- "You make your own story."

PARENTS: YOU'RE NOT ALONE

- You don't have to say yes to every request.
- It's okay to be different from other families.
- Your calm, confident leadership helps them navigate peer pressure.
- Keep the lines of communication open—always.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Friendship matters. Your values matter more.

Help your child choose connection over comparison and confidence over keeping up.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE

0800 1111
childline.org.uk

YOU ARE NOT ALONE
We're here for you.